

Ludic Musicking – List of Citations and Dungeon Rooms

Nicholas Cornia

Orpheus Instituut
nicholas.cornia@orpheusinstituut.be

May 14, 2026

1 Room I

Hint: A man with great strength and as if angry.

Effect: Wandering Monster

Guns do damage, keys open doors, skeletons are weak to magic, cassette tapes contain story fragments. Playing a game means learning this language, the game’s semiotic system, and then using it to assemble larger ideas and meanings. (Lantz 2023, 2)

2 Room II

Hint: A woman, dressed in white garments beneath them, stretching out her foot.

Effect: Treasure

Playing with existing structures is a strategy for questioning and reconfiguring the rules of our lives outside of games. (Zimmerman 2022, 30)

3 Room III

Hint: A young lady playing the lute. Her likeness is as if she was restless and angry because she can’t perform the music she wishes.

Effect: Hazard

An outcome known in advance, with no possibility of error and surprise, clearly leading to an inescapable result, is incompatible with the nature of play. (Caillois [1958] 2001, 7)

4 Room IV

Hint: A man working on a field.

Effect: Hazard

[A game is an] engine for generating horizons of intent. (Upton 2015, 51)

5 Room V

Hint: A man, holding a key in his hand.

Effect: Secret Key

Artgames used the innate properties of games—among them interactivity, game mechanics, and player goals—to create expressive play experiences that explore metaphysical questions around life, ethics, and aspects of the human condition. (Sharp 2015, 49)

6 Room VI

Hint: A man who lost his leg in battle, begging for help.

Effect: Hazard

[...] an imaginary world, no matter how estranging and mysterious, will always be more legible and coherent than ordinary experience—and therefore more appealing. (Saler 2012, 51)

7 Room VII

Hint: A man, whose hand is as if serving another.

Effect: Hazard

My conception of phantasy, as genuine art-form, is an *extension* rather than a negation of reality. (Lovecraft 1971; Saler 2012, 134)

8 Room VIII

Hint: A curved man digging the earth.

Effect: Secret Key

Playing a game is the voluntary effort to overcome unnecessary obstacles. (Suits [1978] 1990, 41)

9 Room IX

Hint: A foolish man who holds in his right hand a bird and in the left a flute.

Effect: Hazard

Assigning meaning to a work is always an act of closure. It's the end of play. (Upton 2015, 283)

10 Room X

Hint: A virgin girl, dressed in pretty clothes, wearing a crown on her head.

Effect: Treasure

Everything leads me to believe that there exists a certain point, a state of mind in which life and death, the real and the imaginary, the past and the future, the communicable and the incommunicable, high and low, cease to be perceived as contradictions. [attributed to André Breton] (Brotchie and Gooding 1995, 136)

11 Room XI

Hint: A man and woman sitting at a table playing.

Effect: Hazard

Through play, the reader is guided along a path—or rather, along various possible paths—through words and images. Starting with a question, the reader-player will find all the answers, and all their negations. Cultural memory is broken down into fragments of verses, condensed into images that the course of the game allows to be recombined. [my translation and paraphrase] (Bolzoni 2012, 218)

12 Room XII

Hint: A man hunting with a lance and horn summoning dogs for the hunt.

Effect: Wandering Monster

[Imaginary worlds] are realms of possibility, a mix of familiar and unfamiliar, permutations of wish, dread, and dream, and other kinds of existence that can make us more aware of the circumstances and conditions of the actual world we inhabit. (Wolf 2014, 17)

13 Room XIII

Hint: A man riding on a lion.

Effect: Wandering Monster

All forms of entertainment strive to create suspension of disbelief, a state in which the player's mind forgets that is being subjected to entertainment and instead accepts what it perceives as reality. (Laramée 2002; Salen and Zimmerman 2004, 450)

14 Room XIV

Hint: A man with his hands raised, with a crown on his head. In his right hand he has a drawn sword and in the left a round shield.

Effect: Wandering Monster

In ordinary practical life, we usually take the means for the sake of the ends. But in games, we can take up an end of the sake of the means. (Nguyen 2020, 1)

15 Room XV

Hint: A young man with a hawk on his hand.

Effect: Wandering Monster

The metaphysicians of Tlön do not seek for the truth or even for verisimilitude, but rather for the astounding. (Borges [1962] 2000) (Borges [1944] 2015, 23)

16 Room XVI

Hint: The figure of a man planting seeds.

Effect: Secret Key

A huge part of what makes childhood play so wholehearted is playing with the rules, not just by them. (Barr 2023, 25)

17 Room XVII

Hint: Two man discussing, one of them holding a satchel.

Effect: Hazard

The truest respect which you can pay to the reader's understanding, is to halve this matter amicably, and leave him something to imagine, in his turn, as well as yourself. For my own part, I am eternally paying him compliments of this kind, and do all that lies in my power to keep his imagination as busy as my own. (Sterne 1759; Bolzoni 2012, 27)

18 Room XVIII

Hint: A deaf or old man, leaning on a stick.

Effect: Hazard

System thinking transcends disciplines and cultures and, when is done right, it overarches history as well. (Meadows 2008, ix)

19 Room XIX

Hint: A man reading a book.

Effect: Artefact Fragment

He who hopes to learn the fine art of the game from books will soon learn that only the opening and closing moves of the game admit of exhaustive systematic description. (Avedon and Sutton-Smith [1971] 2015; Salen and Zimmerman 2004, 28)

20 Room XX

Hint: A man ornately dressed sitting in a chair.

Effect: Artefact Fragment

Play is a cognitive activity in its own right, and as such is just as serious as any other approach to understanding the world around us. [my translation] (Garavaglia 2013, 49)

21 Room XXI

Hint: A man holding with one hand a loaf of bread, on the other a cup of wine.

Effect: Treasure

Extremely complex output can result from extremely simple rules. (Cope 2009, 232)

22 Room XXII

Hint: Two men beating each other.

Effect: Wandering Monster

[A game is] an interactive structure of endogenous meaning that requires players to struggle towards a goal. (Costikyan 2005, 24)

23 Room XXIII

Hint: A man sitting on the ground, and before him are two dogs biting each other.

Effect: Wandering Monster

When I am preparing sketches, [...] I determine points, enter data. I cast the constructed grid like a fisherman casts his net. It is necessary to be patient and watch as space becomes entangled in it. (Ballhausen et al. 2020, 124)

24 Room XXIV

Hint: A man bent over his knee, and a woman beating him with a staff.

Effect: Wandering Monster

Games, I claim, are the crystallization of practicality. (Nguyen 2020, 13)

25 Room XXV

Hint: A strong man armed with a coat of mail, holding a drawn sword in his hand.

Effect: Treasure

Play is carnivalesque too. Play appropriates events, structures, and institutions to mock them and trivialize them, or make them deadly serious (Sicart 2017, 3–4)

26 Room XXVI

Hint: A lamenting woman entirely covered with clothing.

Effect: Hazard

To write a book is to resign oneself to failure, however honorable that failure might be. (Manguel 2015, 9)

27 Room XXVII

Hint: An idle man playing with a staff.

Effect: Hazard

Knowledge often comes in the form of surprise. [my translation](Rodari [1973] 2010, 50)

28 Room XXVIII

Hint: A man bearing full satchels.

Effect: Treasure

An unforeseen touch, away from rules and controlled norms, creates a new path. (Peytchinska and Ballhausen 2018, 135)

29 Room XXIX

Hint: A man gazing at a bird flying in the air.

Effect: Secret Key

[We should consider an artwork as] a field of possibilities, an explicit invitation to exercise choice. (Pousseur 1957)

30 Room XXX

Hint: A banker gathering money on a table.

Effect: Treasure

To play a game is to make an emotional gamble: we invest time and self-esteem in the hope that it will pay off. (Juul 2013, 14)

31 Room XXXI

Hint: A woman spinning.

Effect: Hazard

A rule set is elegant if only a small number of constraints are needed to generate a large number of horizons. (Upton 2015, 57)

32 Room XXXII

Hint: A man sitting on a coffin.

Effect: Hazard

Play cannot be denied. You can deny, if you like, nearly all abstractions: justice, beauty, truth, goodness, mind, God. You can deny seriousness, but not play. (Huizinga [1938] 2016, 3)

33 Room XXXIII

Hint: A man who is pointing at something.

Effect: Hazard

Being a spectator is the opposite of knowing: the spectator is held before an appearance in a state of ignorance about the process of production [...]. It is the opposite of acting. (Rancière 2009, 2)

34 Room XXXIV

Hint: A man carrying a burden over his back, and dressed well.

Effect: Treasure

Play is free movement between a system of constraints. (Upton 2015, 15)

35 Room XXXV

Hint: An ornate man with a good face, pointing at the sky.

Effect: Hazard

Games always exist outside ordinary life, reflecting, commenting on, and resonating with it. (Lantz 2023, 160)

36 Room XXXVI

Hint: A young man, and near him a beautiful maiden, whose head is decorated in flowers.

Effect: Artefact Fragment

There is a very fine balance between play and game, between control and release, lightness and heaviness, concentration and spontaneity. (Bernard DeKove 2006)

Bibliography

- Avedon, Elliott Morton, and Brian Sutton-Smith. (1971) 2015. *The Study of Games*. New York, N.Y.: Ishi Press.
- Ballhausen, Thomas, Elena Peytchinska, Ferdinand Schmatz, Katherina Swoboda, and Boyan Manchev. 2020. *Flora: Sprachkunst im Zeitalter der Information = Flora: language arts in the age of information*. Edition Angewandte. Berlin: De Gruyter.
- Barr, Pippin. 2023. *The Stuff Games Are Made Of*. MIT Press, August 1, 2023. Google Books: [dGmZEAAAQBAJ](#).
- Bernard DeKove. 2006. “Changing the Game.” In *The Game Design Reader: A Rules of Play Anthology*, edited by Katie Salen and Eric Zimmerman, 518–537. Cambridge, Mass: MIT Press.
- Bolzoni, Lina. 2012. *Il Lettore Creativo: Percorsi Cinquecenteschi Fra Memoria, Gioco, Scrittura*. Passaggi e Percorsi. Guida. <https://www.torrossa.com/en/resources/an/4237138>.
- Borges, Jorge Luis. (1944) 2015. *Finzioni*. Translated by Antonio Melis. Gli Adelphi 473. Adelphi.
- . (1962) 2000. *Labyrinths*. Repr. in Penguin classics. Translated by James E. Irby. Penguin Classics. London: Penguin Books.
- Brotchie, Alastair, and Mel Gooding, eds. 1995. *A Book of Surrealist Games*. Boston: Shambhala Redstone Editions.
- Caillois, Roger. (1958) 2001. *Man, Play, and Games*. 1st ed. Chicago, Ill.: University of Illinois Press.
- Cope, David. 2009. *Hidden Structure: Music Analysis Using Computers*. Computer Music and Digital Audio Series, v.DAS23. Middleton: A-R Editions, Inc.
- Costikyan, Greg. 2005. “I Have No Words & I Must Design.” In *The Game Design Reader: A Rules of Play Anthology*, edited by Eric Zimmerman and Katie Salen Tekinbaş, vol. 192. MIT Press. <https://mitpress.mit.edu/9780262195362/the-game-design-reader/>.
- Garavaglia, Valentina. 2013. *Bruno Munari: il gioco del teatro*. Testi e studi 266. Milano: UNICOPLI.
- Huizinga, Johan. (1938) 2016. *Homo Ludens: A Study of the Play-Element in Culture*. Angelico Press.
- Juul, Jesper. 2013. *The Art of Failure: An Essay on the Pain of Playing Video Games*. Playful Thinking. Cambridge, Mass: MIT Press.
- Lantz, Frank. 2023. *The Beauty of Games*. MIT Press. Google Books: [XiGLEAAAQBAJ](#).
- Laramée, François Dominic, ed. 2002. *Game Design Perspectives*. Graphics Series. Hingham, Mass: Charles River Media.

- Lovecraft, H. P. 1971. *Selected Letters. 3: 1929 - 1931 / Ed. by August Derleth*. Edited by August Derleth.
- Manguel, Alberto. 2015. *Curiosity*. New Haven, Conn. London: Yale University Press.
- Meadows, Donella. 2008. *Thinking in Systems. A Primer*. Edited by Diana Wright. London: Earthscan.
- Nguyen, C. Thi. 2020. *Games: Agency As Art*. 1st ed. Oxford University Press New York, June 25, 2020. <https://doi.org/10.1093/oso/9780190052089.001.0001>. <https://academic.oup.com/book/32137>.
- Peytchinska, Elena, and Thomas Ballhausen. 2018. *FAUNA: Sprachkunst und die neue Ordnung imaginärer Tiere. Language Arts and the New Order of Imaginary Animals*. Edition Angewandte. Berlin Boston: De Gruyter.
- Pousseur, Henri. 1957. *Scambi*. <http://www.wikidata.org/entity/Q48834806>.
- Rancière, Jacques. 2009. *The Emancipated Spectator*. London New York: Verso.
- Rodari, Gianni. (1973) 2010. *Grammatica della fantasia: introduzione all'arte di inventare storie*. La biblioteca di Gianni Rodari. Torino: Einaudi Ragazzi.
- Salen, Katie, and Eric Zimmerman. 2004. *Rules of Play: Game Design Fundamentals*. Cambridge, Mass: MIT Press.
- Saler, Michael T. 2012. *As If: Modern Enchantment and the Literary Prehistory of Virtual Reality*. Oxford New York: Oxford University Press.
- Sharp, John. 2015. *Works of Game: On the Aesthetics of Games and Art*. MIT Press.
- Sicart, Miguel. 2017. *Play Matters*. First MIT Press new paperback edition. Cambridge, Massachusetts London, England: The MIT Press.
- Sterne, Laurence. 1759. *The Life and Opinions of Tristram Shandy, Gentleman*. Vol. 2. York, England: Ann Ward.
- Suits, Bernard. (1978) 1990. *The Grasshopper. Games, Life and Utopia*. Toronto: University of Toronto Press.
- Upton, Brian. 2015. *The Aesthetic of Play*. The MIT Press Series. Cambridge, MA: The MIT Press.
- Wolf, Mark. 2014. *Building Imaginary Worlds: The Theory and History of Subcreation*. 1st edition. In collaboration with Safari, an O'Reilly Media Company. Routledge.
- Zimmerman, Eric. 2022. *The Rules We Break: Lessons in Play, Thinking, and Design*. New York: Princeton Architectural Press.